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Culture (OWC): [Ila \(FQ06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1900 AD - 1959 AD

Place Coverage: Zambia

Section Title(S): ILA SLAVERY

The internal slave trade was suppressed in 1917, and the great majority of the slaves were freed by Chief Lewanika of the Barotse who exercised nominal control over the Ila, and by the British South Africa Company.

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Although the majority of slaves were obtained by commercial transaction, it was impossible clearly to differentiate slaves from free Ila. No rigid dichotomy existed, and the term 'slave', therefore, only indicates a person who was not reared in the village. The ambiguous role and indeterminate status of slaves were reflected in the terminology, attitudes, and comments on slave status. An elaborate stereotype concerning slaves was lacking, and slaves were described as people 'who didn't know where their ancestors came from', or 'women who did not receive property in marriage'. The terms applied to these acquired members, or slaves, were *mushike* (sing.) or *bazhike* (pl.) translated either as slave, serf, or servant. *Bantu bulyo* (pl.) also referred to the acquired persons—its translation is 'people inside'. *Nabutema*, meaning either unmarried, or heifer, connoted a special category of women slaves. A joking name, kinship term, or spirit name—the customary method of referring to a free person—was the accepted procedure of addressing the individual who had been purchased. Slaves were regarded primarily as kinsmen, and supposedly received treatment as such. The Ila stress the unlikelihood of slaves being directly referred to by the term *bazhike*, *nabutema*, or *bantu bulyo*.

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As soon as an individual was purchased or captured and brought to a village, attempts were made to incorporate or provide a semblance of kinship affiliation by extending religious protection and identity. The slave's head was shaven and the individual assigned a spirit name associated with a deceased member of the patrilineal unit. The ancestral spirits were informed of this addition and told during a communal ritual to recognize and protect the new member. Thus the relation between the slave and owner was structured within a kinship relationship. The slave's owner was called mother's brother; this genealogical fiction was adopted and extended 72 to the other relatives. The owner of a slave was responsible for the debts and fines incurred by the slave. The Ila rationalized the lack of manumission—although slaves could be resold during hunger periods, as were their own relatives, or accepted as payment for debts—by asking 'how a man could buy himself from his relatives'.

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